He adds that in the circumstances, ‘we had to … make the very painful decision that the future of the Tata group was not going to be’ safe in his hands. And that they had to take a ‘judgement call, not like there’s some empirical evidence’.

To Ratan, Mistry’s perceived departure from the core ethos of the Tata Group presented itself as a binary issue. He could have stepped in to correct the situation, but it would have raised several questions. It would have exposed him to the criticism of still wanting to hold on to the reins that he had willingly given up. The other alternative would have been to remain content with managing the affairs of Tata Trusts and leave the fate of the Tata Group in Mistry’s hands.

To Ratan, at stake were the family values and the wealth bequeathed by the Tatas that he represented as chairman of their Trusts, for charity and social welfare. The danger of the dilution of the authority of the Tata Trusts, combined with the flaws in the functioning of Mistry, made his intervention moot.

Ratan reluctantly veered towards the decision to replace Mistry. It was taken in October 2016, after a span of six months of waiting during which serious thought was given to this step.

Nohria says, ‘I think it was the most difficult decision for him [Ratan] to make … I think people think that he was motivated to make that decision … but his courage to make one of the hardest decisions that he could ever have, that he would ever have to make … knowing full well that it would be costly to his reputation’, was extraordinary.

Ratan knew that ‘he would be misunderstood, that he might receive enormous amount of criticism. I think he underestimated how much that would be but it’s not as if he was naive about the fact that this was going to be, that there would be a fair amount of misunderstanding that might occur on this thing. But still, it tells you that’s the ultimate sacrifice … [he was] even willing to sacrifice some of [his] reputation and honour to do the right thing,’ Nohria adds.

It was a matter of ‘sadness’; ‘I have often racked my brain’ thinking ‘what else could we have done to have allowed Cyrus to be successful’, laments Nohria. ‘It would have been better for the history of the Tata Sons’ to have Mistry ‘to be a successful chairman and CEO’. He concludes by saying that Mistry’s removal ‘was not a desirable outcome’ but had to be done in the interests of the group.